

Unit 1: Introduction to Yoga

Meaning of Yoga :

The word Yoga comes from the Sanskrit root “Yuj”, which means *to join, unite, or yoke*.

Yoga means the union of the body, mind, and soul, leading to harmony within oneself and with the environment.

Definition of Yoga :

Yoga can be defined as:

- A holistic science of healthy living that promotes physical, mental, emotional, and spiritual well-being.
- According to Patanjali, “*Yoga is the cessation of the fluctuations of the mind*” (*Yogah Chitta Vritti Nirodhah*).

This means yoga helps control the mind and attain inner peace.

Need of Yoga :

Yoga is needed because modern life has created many challenges such as stress, anxiety, unhealthy habits, and lack of physical activity. Yoga helps to:

- Reduce stress and mental tension
- Improve concentration and emotional balance
- Prevent lifestyle diseases like obesity, diabetes, and hypertension
- Maintain overall health and inner discipline

Importance of Yoga :

The importance of yoga can be understood in the following ways:

1. Physical Importance

- Improves flexibility, strength, and posture
- Enhances digestion, immunity, and circulation
- Keeps the body active and disease-free

2. Mental Importance

- Increases concentration and memory
- Reduces anxiety, depression, and stress
- Promotes calmness and mental clarity

3. Emotional and Social Importance

- Develops self-confidence and self-control

- Helps manage emotions and relationships better
- Encourages positive thinking and discipline

4. Spiritual Importance

- Helps in self-realization and inner growth
- Brings peace, harmony, and balance in life

Aims of Yoga :

The main aim of yoga is to achieve overall development of a person by creating harmony between the body, mind, and soul. Yoga aims to help an individual live a healthy, balanced, and peaceful life.

Objectives of Yoga :

1. Physical Objectives

- To improve physical strength, flexibility, and endurance
- To maintain proper functioning of body systems
- To prevent diseases and promote good health

2. Mental Objectives

- To develop concentration, memory, and clarity of thought
- To reduce stress, anxiety, and mental disturbances
- To promote emotional stability and inner calm

3. Emotional Objectives

- To control negative emotions like anger, fear, and jealousy
- To develop self-confidence and self-discipline
- To cultivate positive attitudes and behavior

4. Social Objectives

- To promote moral values such as honesty, tolerance, and compassion
- To improve interpersonal relationships
- To create harmony in society

5. Spiritual Objectives

- To attain self-awareness and self-realization
- To purify the mind and consciousness
- To achieve inner peace and liberation (moksha)

Unit 2 : Asanas and Pranayamas

Types of Asanas :

Asanas are physical postures practiced in yoga to improve health and stability of the body.

1. Meditative Asanas

These are practiced mainly for meditation and concentration.

Examples:

- Padmasana
- Sukhasana
- Vajrasana
- Siddhasana

2. Relaxative Asanas

These help in relaxation and removal of fatigue.

Examples:

- Shavasana
- Makarasana

3. Cultural Asanas

These improve physical fitness and flexibility. They are further divided into:

a) Standing Asanas

- Tadasana
- Vrikshasana
- Trikonasana

b) Sitting Asanas

- Paschimottanasana
- Ardha Matsyendrasana

c) Supine (Lying on Back) Asanas

- Bhujangasana
- Chakrasana

d) Prone (Lying on Stomach) Asanas

- Dhanurasana
- Shalabhasana

Types of Pranayama

Pranayama is the practice of controlled breathing to regulate vital energy (prana).

1. Puraka

- Inhalation of breath

2. Rechaka

- Exhalation of breath

3. Kumbhaka

- Retention of breath

Common Types of Pranayama Practices

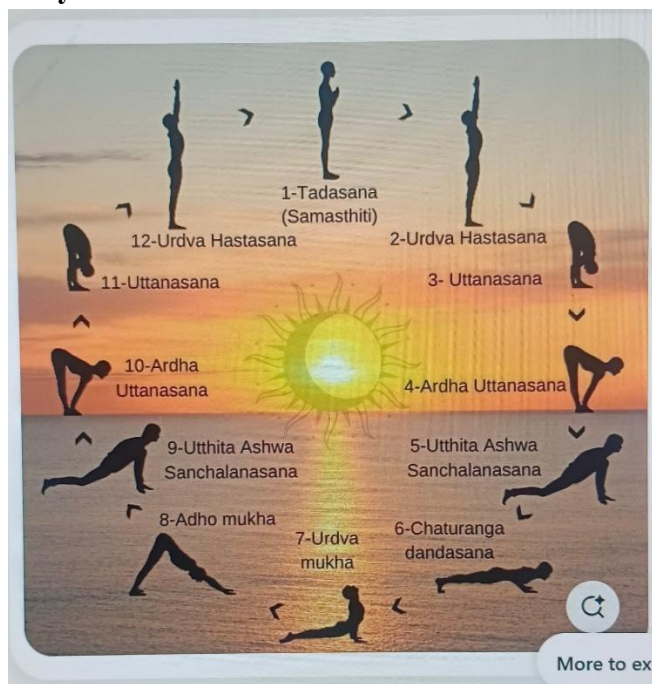
- Anulom Vilom: Alternate nostril breathing
- Bhastrika: Forceful inhalation and exhalation
- Kapalbhati: Rapid exhalation for cleansing
- Bhramari: Humming bee breath
- Ujjayi: Victorious breath
- Sheetali & Sheetkari: Cooling pranayamas

Section – II (Practical)

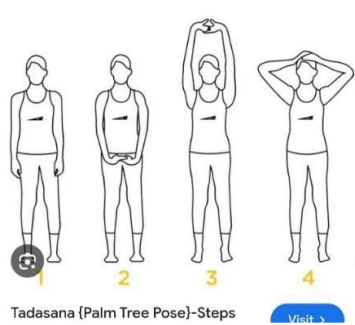
Unit – I Yoga Asanas

1.1 Basic standing Postures / Surya namaskar :

Surya namaskar :



Tadasana (Mountain Pose)



Meaning

Tada means *mountain* and Asana means *posture*.

Tadasana is known as the Mountain Pose because the body stands firm and steady like a mountain.

Procedure (Steps)

1. Stand straight with feet together or slightly apart.
2. Keep arms by the sides and body relaxed.
3. Inhale slowly and raise both arms overhead.
4. Interlock the fingers and turn the palms upward.
5. Raise the heels and balance the body on the toes.
6. Stretch the whole body upward.
7. Hold the position for a few seconds while breathing normally.
8. Exhale, slowly bring heels down, and lower the arms.

Benefits

- Improves posture and body balance
- Increases height in growing children
- Strengthens legs, arms, and spine
- Improves concentration and coordination
- Helps in reducing flat feet

Precautions

- Avoid if suffering from severe back pain, knee problems, or vertigo
- Do not overstretch the body
- Maintain balance carefully

Not allowed to :

- Low blood pressure (perform carefully)
- Recent injury to legs or spine

Virabhadrasana (Warrior Pose)



Meaning

Virabhadra is a legendary warrior in Hindu mythology and Asana means *posture*.

Virabhadrasana is known as the Warrior Pose, symbolizing strength, courage, and determination.

Procedure (Steps)

1. Stand straight in Tadasana.
2. Take a deep breath and step the right foot forward.
3. Bend the right knee so that the thigh becomes parallel to the ground.
4. Keep the left leg straight and firm.
5. Raise both arms overhead, palms facing each other.
6. Keep the chest open and look forward or slightly upward.
7. Hold the posture for 15–30 seconds with normal breathing.
8. Inhale and return to the starting position.
9. Repeat on the other side.

Benefits

- Strengthens legs, arms, shoulders, and back
- Improves stamina, balance, and flexibility
- Enhances concentration and confidence
- Stimulates blood circulation
- Helpful in reducing stiffness of hips and shoulders

Precautions

- Avoid if suffering from severe knee pain or joint problems
- Do not overbend the front knee
- Maintain proper alignment of the body

Not allowed to :

- High blood pressure (raise arms only to shoulder level)

- Heart problems (practice under guidance)

Vrikshasana (Tree Pose)



Meaning

Vriksha means *tree* and Asana means *posture*.

Vrikshasana is called the Tree Pose because the body maintains balance and stability like a tree.

Procedure (Steps)

1. Stand straight in Tadasana with arms by the sides.
2. Shift body weight onto the left leg.
3. Bend the right knee and place the sole of the right foot on the inner thigh of the left leg.
4. Balance the body and join palms together in Namaskar Mudra at the chest.
5. Raise the arms overhead if comfortable.
6. Focus the eyes on a fixed point.
7. Hold the posture for 15–30 seconds with normal breathing.
8. Slowly return to the starting position.
9. Repeat on the other leg.

Benefits

- Improves balance and stability
- Strengthens legs, knees, and ankles
- Enhances concentration and coordination
- Improves posture
- Helps develop mental calmness

Precautions

- Avoid if suffering from knee or ankle injury
- Do not place the foot on the knee joint
- Maintain balance carefully

Not allowed to :

- Vertigo or severe balance disorders

- Low blood pressure (practice cautiously)

Trikonasana (Triangle Pose)



Meaning

Trikona means *triangle* and Asana means *posture*.

Trikonasana is known as the Triangle Pose because the body forms a triangular shape in the final position.

Procedure (Steps)

1. Stand straight in Tadasana.
2. Keep the feet about 3–4 feet apart.
3. Turn the right foot outward and the left foot slightly inward.
4. Stretch both arms sideways at shoulder level.
5. Inhale and bend the body to the right side.
6. Place the right hand on the ankle, shin, or floor (as comfortable).
7. Raise the left arm straight upward.
8. Turn the head and look up at the left hand.
9. Hold the posture for 15–30 seconds with normal breathing.
10. Inhale and return to the starting position.
11. Repeat on the other side.

Benefits

- Increases flexibility of spine and legs
- Strengthens thighs, knees, and ankles
- Improves digestion and circulation
- Reduces backache and stiffness
- Improves balance and posture

Precautions

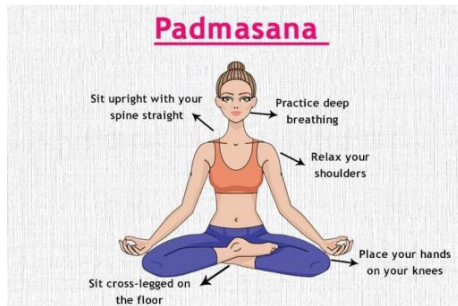
- Avoid overstretching the body
- Do not strain the neck while looking upward
- Practice slowly and with control

Not allowed to :

- Severe back pain or spinal injury
- Vertigo or migraine (keep head neutral)

1.2 Seated Postures

Padmasana (Lotus Pose)



Meaning

Padma means *lotus* and Asana means *posture*.

Padmasana is called the Lotus Pose because the legs resemble the petals of a lotus flower.

Procedure (Steps)

1. Sit on the floor with legs stretched forward.
2. Bend the right leg and place the foot on the left thigh.
3. Bend the left leg and place the foot on the right thigh.
4. Keep the spine straight and shoulders relaxed.
5. Place hands on the knees in Jnana Mudra or Chin Mudra.
6. Close the eyes and breathe normally.
7. Remain in this position for 1–5 minutes or as comfortable.

Benefits

- Improves concentration and mental stability
- Helps in meditation and pranayama
- Keeps the spine erect and strong
- Calms the mind and nervous system
- Helpful in managing stress and anxiety

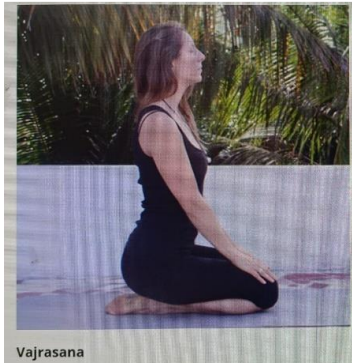
Precautions

- Avoid if suffering from knee, ankle, or hip injuries
- Do not force the legs into position
- Practice gradually under guidance

Not allowed to :

- Severe arthritis
- Recent lower limb surgery

Vajrasana (Thunderbolt / Diamond Pose)



Meaning

Vajra means *thunderbolt* or *diamond* and Asana means *posture*.

Vajrasana is known as the Thunderbolt Pose because it gives strength and stability to the body.

Procedure (Steps)

1. Kneel on the floor with knees together.
2. Stretch the toes backward and keep heels slightly apart.
3. Sit down slowly on the heels so that the buttocks rest on them.
4. Keep the spine straight and head erect.
5. Place hands on the thighs, palms facing downward.
6. Close the eyes and breathe normally.
7. Remain in this position for 2–5 minutes or as comfortable.

Benefits

- Improves digestion (can be practiced after meals)
- Strengthens knees, thighs, and ankles
- Improves posture and spinal health
- Calms the mind and improves concentration
- Helpful in reducing acidity and indigestion

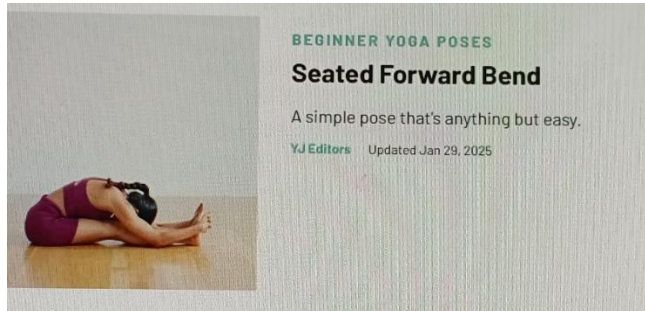
Precautions

- Avoid if suffering from severe knee pain or joint problems
- Do not strain the ankles
- Practice on a soft surface if needed

Not allowed to :

- Arthritis of knees
- Slip disc or severe lower back problems

Paschimottanasana (Seated Forward Bend)



Meaning

Paschima means *west* (back side of the body), Uttana means *stretch*, and Asana means *posture*. Paschimottanasana is the posture that stretches the entire back side of the body from head to heels.

Procedure (Steps)

1. Sit on the floor with legs stretched straight forward.
2. Keep the spine erect and hands by the sides.
3. Inhale and raise both arms upward.
4. Exhale and slowly bend forward from the hips.
5. Hold the toes or ankles with the hands.
6. Try to touch the forehead to the knees without bending the legs.
7. Breathe normally and hold the position for 15–30 seconds.
8. Inhale and slowly return to the starting position.

Benefits

- Stretches the spine, shoulders, and hamstrings
- Improves digestion and relieves constipation
- Reduces belly fat
- Calms the mind and reduces stress
- Helpful in diabetes and obesity

Precautions

- Do not jerk or force the body forward
- Keep knees straight but not strained
- Practice slowly and with control

Not allowed to :

- Slip disc or severe back pain
- Hernia
- Pregnancy

Garudasana (Eagle Pose)



Meaning

Garuda means *eagle* and Asana means *posture*.

Garudasana is called the Eagle Pose because the body twists and balances like an eagle in flight.

Procedure (Steps)

1. Stand straight in Tadasana with arms by the sides.
2. Bend the right knee slightly and cross the right thigh over the left thigh.
3. Hook the right foot behind the left calf if possible.
4. Stretch both arms forward, cross the right arm over the left at the elbows.
5. Bend the elbows and try to bring palms together.
6. Keep the spine straight and focus on a point in front.
7. Hold the posture for 15–30 seconds while breathing normally.
8. Release slowly and repeat on the other side.

Benefits

- Improves balance and concentration
- Strengthens legs, ankles, and arms
- Stretches shoulders, hips, and thighs
- Enhances coordination and body awareness
- Helps relieve fatigue and stress

Precautions

- Avoid if you have knee, hip, or shoulder injuries

- Perform slowly to maintain balance
- Do not overstretch arms or legs

Not allowed to :

- Severe joint pain or arthritis
- Vertigo or balance disorders

Unit – II Pranayamas and Meditation

2.1 Pranayamas

Anulom Vilom (Alternate Nostril Breathing)



Meaning

Anulom Vilom is a type of Pranayama in yoga.

- Anulom means *with the natural flow*
- Vilom means *against the natural flow*

It is also called Alternate Nostril Breathing because you breathe through one nostril at a time, alternating between the left and right.

Procedure (Steps)

1. Sit comfortably in Vajrasana, Padmasana, or Sukhasana with spine erect.
2. Place the left hand on the left knee in Jnana Mudra.
3. With the right hand, fold the index and middle fingers (or use thumb and ring finger).
4. Close the right nostril with the thumb and inhale slowly through the left nostril.
5. Close the left nostril with the ring finger, release the thumb, and exhale through the right nostril.
6. Inhale through the right nostril.
7. Close the right nostril and exhale through the left nostril.
8. This completes one round. Repeat for 5–10 minutes.

Benefits

- Balances the left and right hemispheres of the brain
- Reduces stress, anxiety, and tension

- Improves concentration and memory
- Cleanses the respiratory system
- Regulates blood pressure and heart rate

Precautions

- Do not force the breath
- Practice on an empty stomach
- Sit in a comfortable, upright posture

Not allowed to :

- Severe asthma or breathing difficulties (practice under guidance)
- Heart problems (practice slowly)

Sheetali Pranayama (Cooling Breath)



Meaning

Sheetali comes from the Sanskrit word “Sheetal”, which means *cooling*. Sheetali Pranayama is a breathing technique that cools down the body and mind.

Procedure (Steps)

1. Sit comfortably in Padmasana, Sukhasana, or Vajrasana with a straight spine.
2. Place hands on the knees in Jnana Mudra.
3. Roll the tongue into a tube shape (for some, just curl the sides of the tongue).
4. Inhale slowly through the rolled tongue.
5. Close the mouth and exhale slowly through the nostrils.
6. Repeat for 5–10 rounds with slow, deep breathing.

Note: If you cannot roll the tongue, you can inhale through slightly parted lips (this is called Sheetkari Pranayama).

Benefits

- Reduces body heat and lowers fever
- Calms the mind and reduces stress

- Helps control blood pressure
- Improves digestion
- Refreshes the body and mind

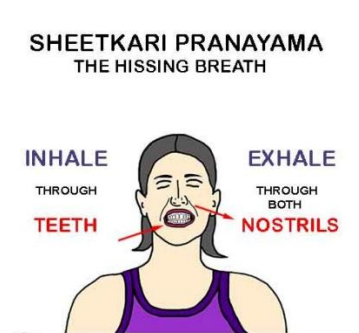
Precautions

- Do not force the breath
- Practice on an empty stomach
- Sit in a comfortable posture with a straight spine

Not allowed to :

- People with low blood pressure (can cause dizziness)
- Severe respiratory disorders

Sheetkari Pranayama (Hissing Breath)



Meaning

Sheetkari comes from the Sanskrit word “Sheetal”, which means *cooling*.

Sheetkari Pranayama is a breathing technique that cools the body and calms the mind, similar to Sheetali Pranayama, but inhalation is done through the teeth with a hissing sound.

Procedure (Steps)

1. Sit comfortably in Padmasana, Sukhasana, or Vajrasana with a straight spine.
2. Place hands on the knees in Jnana Mudra.
3. Part the teeth slightly and fold the tongue to touch the upper palate.
4. Inhale slowly through the teeth, making a hissing sound.
5. Close the mouth and exhale slowly through the nostrils.
6. Repeat for 5–10 rounds with slow, deep breathing.

Note: The sound produced during inhalation resembles soft hissing.

Benefits

- Lowers body temperature and reduces heat-related problems
- Calms the mind and reduces stress and anxiety

- Helps in controlling high blood pressure
- Improves digestion and relieves acidity
- Refreshes and energizes the body

Precautions

- Practice on an empty stomach
- Do not strain while inhaling
- Maintain an erect posture during practice

Not allowed to :

- Low blood pressure (can cause dizziness)
- Severe respiratory issues

Bhramari Pranayama (Humming Bee Breath)



Meaning

Bhramari comes from the Sanskrit word “Bhramar”, meaning *bee*.

This pranayama is called Humming Bee Breath because, while exhaling, a sound similar to a humming bee is produced.

Procedure (Steps)

1. Sit comfortably in Padmasana, Sukhasana, or Vajrasana with a straight spine.
2. Close the eyes and relax the body.
3. Place the index fingers gently on the ears (optional: you can also place hands on knees in Jnana Mudra).
4. Take a deep breath in through both nostrils.
5. Close the ears with fingers and slowly exhale while making a humming sound like a bee (Bhramari).
6. Focus on the sound and vibration throughout the head.
7. Repeat for 5–10 rounds.

Benefits

- Reduces stress, anxiety, and anger
- Improves concentration and memory
- Calms the mind and nervous system
- Helps in controlling blood pressure
- Promotes mental clarity and inner peace

Precautions

- Practice on an empty stomach
- Sit comfortably with a straight spine
- Do not force the humming sound

Not allowed to :

- Severe respiratory problems
- Ear infections or ear pain (avoid pressure on ears)

2.2 Meditation

Om Chanting / Omkar

Meaning

Om (ॐ) is a sacred sound and symbol in Hinduism, Yoga, and spiritual practices.

- It represents the primordial sound of the universe and the ultimate reality (Brahman).
- Om is considered the source of all creation, encompassing past, present, and future.

Omkar means the vibration or chanting of Om.



Procedure (Steps)

1. Sit comfortably in Padmasana, Sukhasana, or Vajrasana with a straight spine.
2. Close your eyes and relax the body.
3. Take a deep breath and inhale slowly.
4. Chant “Om” slowly and steadily.

- Pronounce it as A-U-M, where:
 - A (ah) – beginning of the sound
 - U (oo) – middle part
 - M (mmm) – end, with lips closed
- 5. Focus on the vibration in the chest, head, and whole body.
- 6. Exhale naturally and remain silent for a few seconds.
- 7. Repeat 5–10 times or as comfortable.

Benefits

- Calms the mind and reduces stress
- Improves concentration and memory
- Helps in meditation and spiritual growth
- Balances energy and promotes harmony in the body
- Strengthens the nervous system

Precautions

- Practice on an empty stomach for better effect
- Sit comfortably with spine erect
- Do not strain your voice; chant gently

Not allowed to :

- None specifically; safe for most people
- Avoid excessive chanting if you feel dizziness or strain